

tl;dr Notes on Nonlinear Wave Equations

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Contents

1	Linear Wave Equation	3
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Overview

The following is a tl;dr version of the lecture notes on nonlinear wave equations I am writing in preparation for the SBU math PhD oral exam. The purpose of these notes aren't to include every single detail/computation that is inside the main set of notes, but rather to point out the important ideas, techniques, and perspectives.

1 Linear Wave Equation

- **(Cauchy Linear Wave Problem)** Let ϕ be a function (or distribution) of appropriate regularity on $I \times \mathbb{R}^n$, and let $\square = \partial_{tt} - \Delta$ be the d'Alembertian operator. Then the Cauchy wave problem on $I \times \mathbb{R}^n$ is

$$\begin{cases} \square \phi = f, \\ (\phi, \partial_t \phi) \upharpoonright_{\{t=0\}} = (\phi_0, \phi_1) \end{cases},$$

where f (potentially zero) is some source term.

- **(Well-Posedness of the Cauchy Problem)** A desired property for the Cauchy problem. We require the following three conditions:
 1. Existence of a solution;
 2. Uniqueness of the solution;
 3. Continuous dependence of the solution on the initial data (small perturbation in the initial data leads to a small perturbation in the solution).
- **(Energy of a Solution; Homogeneous)** Assuming a solution ϕ exists to $\square \phi = 0$, define the energy $E(t)$ to be

$$E(t) = \frac{1}{2} \int_{\mathbb{R}^n} (\partial_t \phi)^2 + (\nabla \phi)^2 dx.$$

(1) The energy is always conserved, and (2) gives uniqueness of solution (if a solution exists) by considering the difference of two solutions which must have zero energy at $t = 0$ (compare this to elliptic and parabolic equations, whose uniqueness of solutions can be given by a maximum principle).

- **(Energy Estimate of a Solution; Nonhomogeneous)** Assume $\partial_\alpha (a^{\alpha\beta} \partial_\beta \phi) = F$, where $a_{\alpha\beta}$ is some metric (close enough to the standard Minkowski metric $g_{\alpha\beta}$). Let $|\partial \phi|^2 := (\partial_t \phi)^2 + (\nabla \phi)^2$. Although $\|\partial \phi\|_{C([0,T])}$ is not conserved, it is bounded above by the $\dot{H}^1(\mathbb{R}^n) \times L^2(\mathbb{R}^n)$ norm of the initial data, and the L^2 norm of the source term.
- **(Fundamental Solutions)** Distributional solutions to the wave equation,

$$\begin{cases} \square E_+ = \delta_0, \\ \text{supp}(E_+) \subseteq \{(t, x) : 0 \leq |x| \leq t\} \end{cases},$$

I.e., a distribution E_+ solving $\square E_+ = \delta_0$ that is supported on the forward light cone based at the origin.

Key Facts: (1) the support of the fundamental solution grows with time (i.e., solutions to the wave equation propagation), (2) if a fundamental solution exists, then it propagates at finite speed, (3) a *unique* fundamental solution exists:

$$E_+(t, x) = -\frac{\pi^{\frac{1-n}{2}}}{2} \chi_{\{t \geq 0\}} \chi_+^{\frac{1-n}{2}}(t^2 - |x|^2),$$

where

$$\chi_+^a(y) := \frac{y^a \chi_{\{y \geq 0\}}}{\Gamma(a+1)};$$

i.e.,

$$E_+(t, x) = -\frac{\pi^{\frac{1-n}{2}}}{2} \chi_{\{t \geq 0\}} \frac{1}{\Gamma(\frac{3-n}{2})^{\frac{n-1}{2}}} \frac{1}{(t^2 - |x|^2)^{\frac{n-1}{2}}} \chi_{\{|x| \leq t\}},$$

(4) can be used to derive general representation formulas for the wave equation ($\square \phi = F$):

$$\phi(t, x) = -E_+ * (\phi_1 \delta_{\{t=0\}}) - (\partial_t E_+) * (\phi_0 \delta_{\{t=0\}}) + (F \chi_{\{t \geq 0\}}) * E_+,$$

(5) can be used to understand pointwise decay estimates of solutions.